the second century BCE, where historical kings figure. Prasenajit of Kosala, for instance, is shown on a chariot drawn by four richly caparisoned horses with attendants and riders, while Ajatashatru of Magadha is depicted sitting on a state elephant with the others accompanying the leader controlled by female mahouts.[5] Like military expeditions, the itineraries of travelling kings were presumably planned well in advance, with calculated halts on the way in villages, towns, and forests.[6] The forethought that went into these expeditions was crucial because, to facilitate the movement of sovereigns and armies, travel tracks had to be made suitable for such retinues. It is for this reason that Bharata, younger brother of Rama of the *Ramayana*, is said to have first organized technical people and labourers to construct the road to Chitrakuta on which he would travel when trying to persuade Rama to return and assume the throne at Ayodhya. The arrangements in that instance were so elaborate—with topographers, guides, surveyors, masons, carpenters, diggers, and even tree planters involved in the expedition—that the trade routes scholar Moti Chandra was reminded of modern sappers and miners who level the ground, chop trees, repair roads, and construct new ones.[7]

Ashoka as newly appointed viceroy is likely to have undertaken his march to Malwa in a similar style, even if his accompanying entourage, by virtue of his being viceroy and not king, may well have been smaller than those depicted on ancient sculptural reliefs and described in epic tales.

If Ashoka began his journey from Pataliputra, the track he followed was well trodden, forming part of the long traverse of a network of routes known collectively as Dakshinapatha, or the southern route. It was along the Dakshinapatha that Jivaka, the physician of Rajagriha who trained in Taxila, went to the court of Pradyota, the king of Ujjayini, at the king's request, to cure him of jaundice.[8] Among the more frequent travellers were traders in caravans ('sartha') carrying goods from the regions south of the central highlands. Ranging from the Deccan and peninsular India to the